# Muse

A Saudi product company that builds its own software and helps other businesses build theirs properly.

Who we are, what we believe, the three pillars we run, the standard we hold, and where things actually stand.

| DATE | PREPARED BY | REFERENCE | STATUS |
| --- | --- | --- | --- |
| 2026-07-30 | Abdullah Alsubaie | MUSE-EXP-01 | Internal |

## 01 Who we are

A product company that funds itself with client work. Premium in craft, human in how it talks, business first and at startup speed. Not a low cost development shop, not a body shop, not a freelancer collective. We do take client projects, including brand and marketing work, and that is most of the income at the start. The distinction is trajectory rather than denial: an agency's ceiling is the hours it can sell, and ours is not.

Saudi first is not decoration. Arabic and RTL are first class in everything we build, we hire here and give people work that builds their careers, and our products are made for how people actually live here. That last one is the only durable advantage we have over a foreign product with a bigger team.

### Where this goes

A respected Saudi product company known for shipping exceptional software, and for raising the general quality of software experiences in the Kingdom. That is meant to buy two things: institutional access, so the entities backing startups here already know the name, and standing for the people who work here, who should leave more known and more employable than they arrived.

### Three pillars, one brand

**PILLAR 01**

**Product Ventures**

Our own apps. The long game, and where company value accumulates.

Nothing for a while, then possibly a lot

**PILLAR 02**

**Brand and Marketing**

Audience, reputation and reach, and what they buy.

No direct revenue. Makes the other two cheaper

**PILLAR 03**

**Client Services**

Product, design, build, brand and marketing work for other companies.

Pays for everything at the start. Project based, lumpy

- Client work funds Ventures and Marketing, and surfaces real problems worth building products around
- Marketing means client work arrives inbound rather than by chasing, which raises what we can charge and lets us say no
- Marketing gives every venture launch a starting audience instead of a cold App Store listing
- Ventures prove we can ship, which is what makes a serious client trust us with their product

| PILLAR | RESPONSIBLE | SUPPORTED BY |
|---|---|---|
| **Product Ventures** | **Design lead** | Technical lead, when an idea needs turning into something buildable. Founder on direction and the traction gate |
| **Brand and Marketing** | **Marketing lead** | Graphic design and production help, plus the team appearing in and contributing content |
| **Client Services** | **Founder** | Technical lead on everything technical, plus whoever else the engagement needs |

One person is responsible per pillar and everyone supports across all three. Client work has first call on shared capacity, because that is what pays salaries, and when there is no active client demand the default work is Ventures and Marketing rather than waiting.

# 02 What we believe

Plenty of excellent product ideas already exist and already work. Inventing from scratch is expensive, slow and usually unnecessary. So we find products proven somewhere else, understand why they work, and build the version that fits here.

Success is already proven, so the effort goes into execution rather than into the idea. That is not a theory: it is how most of the software people here use every day was actually built.

| COMPANY | MODEL IT TOOK | WHAT HAPPENED |
| --- | --- | --- |
| **Careem (كريم)** | Ride hailing, the Uber model | Founded in Dubai in 2012 and built for the region. Uber acquired it for USD 3.1 billion, completed January 2020 |
| **Jahez (جاهز)** | Food delivery | Saudi founded. Listed on Nomu, the Saudi parallel market, in 2022 at SAR 850 per share, implying a valuation around SAR 8.9 billion and raising about SAR 1.6 billion |
| **HungerStation** | Food delivery | Founded in Saudi Arabia in 2012. Majority acquired by Foodpanda in 2016, which took it into Delivery Hero. Delivery Hero bought the remaining 37 percent in July 2023 for about USD 297 million |
| **Haraj (حراج)** | Online classifieds, the Craigslist model | Founded 2007. Started with cars, then property, then everything. Now one of the largest classifieds platforms in the region |

## The published thinking

- **Theodore Levitt, "Innovative Imitation", Harvard Business Review, 1966.** Most newness in business comes from imitation rather than invention, so companies should run a deliberate imitation strategy alongside original development. His sharpest finding: not one of the firms he studied had one, they all did it accidentally.
- **Oded Shenkar, "Copycats", Harvard Business Review Press, 2010.** Innovators capture only a small share of the value they create, and disciplined imitators often capture more. He puts imitation at roughly 25 to 33 percent cheaper, because the imitator saves on research and on the market education the first mover paid for. He is explicit that he means the legal forms of imitation only.
- **Kai-Fu Lee, "AI Superpowers", 2018.** Meituan started as a Groupon clone, beat thousands of competitors and became one of the most valuable companies in China. Lee's point is the second order one: the copycat phase built a generation of operators with skills the market did not have before, and they went on to build things nobody had copied. That applies here too. Even the attempts that fail leave a team that can ship.

**THE HONEST COUNTERARGUMENT**

Peter Thiel's position in "Zero to One" is the well known opposing view: copying what works takes the world from one to n, and real value comes from doing something nobody has done. It is a serious argument and it is not wrong about where the largest outcomes come from. Our answer is not that he is wrong, it is that the two are answering different questions. Zero to one is a strategy for a company that can survive years of uncertainty. We fund ourselves with client work, so taking proven demand into a genuinely underserved market is the version we can execute. Section 03 is where our own originality goes.

# 03 Localisation is the product

This is the part that stops the model being cloning. A translated copy of a foreign app is one App Store update away from being taken back. What cannot be taken back is depth in a market the original owner does not understand. Three moves, and they apply to any category.

### Local institutions

The businesses, chains and services that exist here and that a foreign product has no relationship with. Hardest to copy, because it is relationships and integration work rather than software.

### Local context

Not a setting. The product behaves differently because life here is different: the calendar, Ramadan, prayer times, the weekend, how families decide, how people pay.

### Local language

Native Arabic, including the vocabulary of that specific domain, which is usually where a translated app gives itself away.

## A worked example, not a plan

Fitness makes the clearest illustration. Taking a well made international workout tracker as the reference, and adding one small thing it does not do:

- Direct integration with the gym chains people here use, so check in happens in our app
- Detecting which gym you are in and loading that gym's real equipment list, so the workout you plan is one you can actually do
- An AI layer that says which muscles you have been missing and suggests something possible with the machines in front of you
- Arabic gym vocabulary as people here really say it, not a literal translation

## Read the shape, not the subject. The same pattern in other categories

| CATEGORY | LOCAL INSTITUTIONS | LOCAL CONTEXT | THE SMALL ADDITION |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Nutrition** | Restaurant and cafe chains, supermarket barcodes | Shared platter portions, Ramadan eating patterns | An Arabic description of a mixed plate, broken into components |
| **Personal finance** | The banks and wallets people use, local merchant names | Salary timing, family obligations, no interest preferences | Categorisation that recognises local merchants correctly |
| **Home services** | Real local providers, not a directory of nobody | Weekend and prayer time scheduling, compound realities | Trust signals matching how people choose a stranger to let in |
| **Learning** | Local curricula, universities, certification bodies | The academic calendar, exam periods | Arabic first content, not translated courses |

**PROOF THAT THIS IS WHAT WINS**

Grab and Gojek took the ride hailing model and beat Uber in their own markets, to the point that Uber sold its Southeast Asia business to Grab. They won on adaptation, not on capital or interface: motorbikes rather than cars, because that is what moves through traffic in Jakarta and Hanoi, and cash long after Western platforms went card only, because most people were unbanked.

# 04 Our own products

Portfolio logic. Most attempts will not work, and that is the model rather than a failure. One hit pays for every miss, so the cost of each attempt matters more than the odds on any single one.

> Keep taking cheap shots until one of them is the golden egg, then put real weight behind it.

## Not a research project

We do not spend a long stretch validating whether people want the kind of product we are adapting. Millions already pay for the original, so the expensive question is answered. What is unanswered is whether our version wins here, and no amount of interviewing settles that. Shipping settles it.

So what we manage is the cost of an attempt rather than the certainty of it. Build a real MVP, publish it properly, and let the market answer. MVP means small in scope. It does not mean rough, because publishing something broken teaches us nothing about the idea and wastes the attempt.

## The traction gate decides

Launch is the middle of the process, not the end. Instrument before publishing, set the review date on launch day, then decide with the metric in front of you. Three outcomes, and each one gets recorded:

| OUTCOME | WHAT IT MEANS |
|---|---|
| **Invest** | Real signs of life. More people, more money, a proper roadmap |
| **One more push** | Something specific is broken and we know what. One fix and one new review date, and only once, otherwise this becomes a way of never deciding |
| **Move on** | Leave it live if it costs nothing to run, stop spending attention on it, write down what was learned, start the next one |

Retention over installs. Installs measure the launch push, retention measures the product. The bar itself is not set yet and it needs to be before the first launch, because setting it after seeing the numbers is how a dead product survives for a year.

## Who runs it, and what is still open

The design lead owns this pillar and keeps it as their main focus, so it does not stop the moment a client appears. Technical support comes in early, throwing ideas around while the idea is still soft, rather than receiving a finished handover.

No category is chosen yet, and the candidate list is being widened before one is. The method works on any category where a proven product exists and nobody has built the local version properly, which is a large space, so choosing early from a short list would be the wrong trade.

# 05 Brand and marketing

This pillar produces no invoices, which is exactly why it is named as a pillar rather than treated as something to do when there is time. Reach with no purpose behind it is a hobby, so here is what the audience is actually for.

| WHAT IT CONVERTS INTO | WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE WHEN IT IS WORKING |
|---|---|
| **Inbound client work** | A prospect arrives already knowing the standard of our work, so the conversation starts at scope rather than at credentials. Better projects, less negotiation, higher prices |
| **Distribution for our own products** | Every venture launch otherwise starts from zero, and an attempt can fail from invisibility rather than from being wrong. A first hundred users willing to try things and say what is broken is worth more at MVP stage than a thousand indifferent installs |
| **Institutional access** | The entities that back startups here, ministries and large organisations already know the name when a conversation starts. What earns that is shipped work, being the recognised name in something specific, and showing up in person |
| **Standing for the people here** | Anyone who works at Muse should leave more known and more employable than they arrived. That is part of the deal, and it is why people post under their own names |

## What we actually post

- **Useful craft content.** Techniques, breakdowns, the thing someone saves and sends to a colleague. Arabic and RTL specifics are our strongest territory and nobody local owns it yet
- **Free assets.** Templates, checklists, starter kits. Highest saves and shares of anything we can post, because using our template puts our standard inside somebody's work
- **Behind the scenes.** Real working sessions, the ugly first version, the disagreement left in. Nobody refers a studio, they refer people they feel like they know
- **Working in the open.** Ventures while they are unfinished, decisions and why, including the ones we reversed
- **Opinion.** Positions on software quality here and on Arabic in products. Highest risk and highest return, and never about a named local company's failures

## The voice

Close to people, not corporate. We say we and I, people appear by name, and we post the messy middle rather than only the finished thing. This is a positioning choice rather than a style preference: the established local firms all sound the same, and sounding like them makes a small company sound smaller, not larger. What it does not mean is sloppy. The craft is the point, and the voice is just how we talk about it.

Personal accounts do the heavy lifting. In this market a logo posting a tutorial gets a fraction of the reach the same tutorial gets from a named person, so the team posts as themselves and the company account amplifies and holds the official material. Nobody is required to post.

> **WHERE THIS ACTUALLY STANDS**
>
> The accounts exist and are live. None of them are activated: no logo, no bio, no content. An account with no logo and no posts reads as abandoned, which is worse than not existing, so activation comes before publishing anything.

# 06 Client work

Consulting and delivery for companies who need product, design, development, brand or marketing work. This is the main source of income at the beginning and there is nothing embarrassing about that. It funds the other two pillars, teaches us what businesses here struggle with, and produces the case studies that make the next client easier to win.

| WHAT THEY ARE BUYING | WHAT IS ON THE MENU |
|---|---|
| **Think** | Product strategy, UX research, product consulting, feature design, product growth review |
| **Design** | UI design, product redesign, design systems, gamification |
| **Build** | Mobile applications, web applications, API integrations, automation, AI integrations |
| **Brand and marketing** | Brand identity, brand refresh, graphic design, marketing strategy, content and social, Arabic copy written natively rather than translated |
| **Advise** | Technical architecture guidance |

We are strongest where brand meets product: an identity that survives contact with a real interface, Arabic included. Most branding studios hand over a logo and a document and have never had to build with it. That work is delivered by the same people who run our own accounts, so our own posting goes quieter while a client project is live. A known trade rather than a surprise.

## Named engagement shapes, proposed

A menu invites line item shopping and price comparison. Named engagements do not. These shapes are drafted, and none is priced or agreed yet.

- **Product Audit.** Fixed scope, fixed price. The best first engagement: low commitment for the client, and it usually reveals the real work. It also puts us in the diagnosing position rather than the quoting position
- **Discovery Sprint.** Problem to defined scope, fixed price
- **Build.** Scoped from a completed Discovery
- **Brand Sprint.** Identity or refresh, fixed scope and price
- **Product Partner.** Retainer, ongoing product and design capacity

## What we do not sell

- Body shopping. Developers rented by the month with no product involvement
- Anything where we have no access to users and no say in the decisions
- Work at a price that requires cutting the quality bar to make money on it

Two habits keep us from becoming an agency. Sell outcomes rather than hours, because the moment we quote a day rate against a list of screens the relationship is transactional forever. And keep the product view, because a client asking for a redesign usually has a business problem underneath.

There are no engagements yet. Until the marketing engine is running, work arrives through the network rather than inbound. That is the honest position for now.

# 07 Our standard

The standard is identical for our own products and for client work. Craftsmanship is the claim we make, and this is the only thing that makes the claim true. Work that does not clear it does not go out.

| THE STANDARD | WHAT IT MEANS IN PRACTICE |
|---|---|
| **Production grade** | No prototype code in production. No hardcoded values that should be configuration. Nothing commented out and left behind. If something is temporary it carries a note saying when it goes |
| **Real data only** | No lorem, no placeholder charts, no fake numbers, no sample avatars. Where real data does not exist yet, the design uses realistic data a person from here would recognise. Fake data hides the real problems: the name that is too long, the price with three digits, the empty state nobody designed |
| **Known, predictable behaviour** | Every state is designed and built: empty, loading, error, offline, first run, full, and permission denied where it applies. If you cannot say what the product does in a state, it is not finished |
| **Micro interactions** | Transitions, feedback on tap, focus states, keyboard and scroll behaviour. Nothing moves without a reason, nothing takes longer than it needs to, and every action is acknowledged immediately even when the result takes time |
| **Arabic and RTL first class** | Not a later phase. A product that only holds up in English is not done |

## Before saying done

- [ ] Works in Arabic and English, both directions, on a real device
- [ ] Every state above exists and has been seen
- [ ] No fake data anywhere
- [ ] Tested on the oldest device we care about, not just the newest
- [ ] Someone other than the author has used it without instructions
- [ ] Contrast checked, touch targets large enough, works with larger system text
- [ ] Nothing in the console. No errors, and no warnings we have stopped noticing
- [ ] Copy reviewed, and Arabic reviewed by someone who writes Arabic well

## Right sizing

Not everything needs the same treatment, so be explicit about which of the three a piece of work is. **Throwaway** is an internal experiment nobody outside will see: speed over polish, and it never becomes production without a rewrite. **Internal** is a tool our own team uses: correct and clear, polish optional. **Shipped** is anything someone outside can see: the full bar, no exceptions. The failure is a throwaway drifting into shipped without anyone deciding, so name it at the start.

> THE HABIT UNDERNEATH ALL OF IT
>
> Claiming something works without seeing it work is the fastest way to lose trust, internally and with a client. Run it. Look at it. In both languages. Then say it is done.

# 08 Where we are

Where things actually stand, without rounding anything up. This is the part of the picture that changes fastest, and the open questions below are genuinely open.

| WHERE THINGS ARE | STATUS | NOTE |
|---|---|---|
| **Brand identity** | **Done** | Orange on maroon, produced and settled. It is what gets applied to everything |
| **Website** | **In progress** | The owned surface. Everything else points here |
| **Social accounts** | **Live, not activated** | Created, but no logo, no bio and no content on any of them |
| **Client work** | **None yet** | The first engagements come through the network |
| **Our own products** | **None built** | No category chosen, and the candidate list is being widened first |
| **Written thinking** | **Current** | The vault behind this document holds the full detail |

## What is genuinely still open

Each of these blocks real work, and each needs a decision rather than more discussion.

| OPEN QUESTION | WHAT IT BLOCKS |
|---|---|
| **The name, trademark and handles** | Signage, domains, filings |
| **How close is too close to a reference product** | Every venture. The whole model starts from someone else's product, so this is the one that matters most |
| **What counts as traction** | Every launch, and every decision to stop |
| **Which category we start in, and whether to spread or wedge** | Every venture, and what marketing builds an audience for |
| **Which audience we build first** | The content mix and which channels we run |
| **Which client work we decline** | Protecting the other two pillars |
| **What a good quarter looks like** | Knowing whether any of this is working |

**THE RISK WORTH NAMING IN ADVANCE**

Client work always feels more urgent than a venture, because someone is waiting and there is an invoice at the end. The failure mode is a long run of full client load at the end of which nothing of our own has shipped, and the company is an agency that talks about products. The check against it is writing down where each week actually went, and a long stretch with no venture progress means either turning work down or hiring.

# 09 Sources and further reading

Every number and claim in sections 02 and 03 traces to a single research note, and the links below are the primary sources behind it. Anything that could not be verified against a primary source was left out rather than softened.

## Saudi precedents

**Uber and Careem.** Charles River Associates, and Uber's filings on EDGAR

**Jahez listing.** Arab News on the offer, and Arab News on the debut valuation

**HungerStation.** Delivery Hero newsroom, and Forbes Middle East

**Haraj.** Tracxn company profile

## International precedents and the published thinking

**Grab and Gojek.** Fast Company, Fortune, and Harvard Business School Digital Initiative on Gojek

**Theodore Levitt.** "Innovative Imitation", Harvard Business Review, September 1966

**Oded Shenkar.** "Copycats", Harvard Business Review Press, and the HBR IdeaCast interview

## Where the rest of it lives

This document is a compression. The full thinking sits in a vault of plain markdown notes: the positioning, the product philosophy, the business lines and the capacity rule, the quality bar, the localisation playbook, the research note behind section 02, and a decision log that records not only what was decided but what was rejected and why. If something here raises a question, the answer is almost certainly in there at length.

The order worth reading them in: Positioning, Product Philosophy, Business Lines, Localisation Precedents, Quality Bar.

> **KEEPING THIS HONEST**
>
> The vault is a folder of plain markdown, so access means a copy of the folder and any editor that reads it. Ask the founder. This document is generated from source rather than hand edited, so when something changes it gets rebuilt rather than patched, and section 08 is the part that will be wrong first.